BEYOND BIAS

PARTICIPATORY DESIGN FOR INCLUSIVE AI

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BACKGROUND

Generative AI systems are increasingly embedded in cultural production, and creative industries. However, these systems are trained on datasets that disproportionately privilege Western visual cultures, dominant languages, and hegemonic socio-cultural norms. As a result, generative AI often reproduces:

- cultural erasure
- underrepresentation of marginalized communities
- biased aesthetic outputs
- extractive data practices
- opaque provenance and authorship systems

The Beyond Bias initiative investigates how participatory design methodologies can support the development of more inclusive, accountable, and culturally responsive generative AI systems.



PROJECT OVERVIEW

Beyond Bias is a collaboration between Gooey.AI and Goethe-Institut India focused on participatory approaches to generative AI development. The initiative began by creating a consortium of 24 institutional stakeholders across US, UK, EU and India. Over two roundtables they collaboratively authored an open manifesto articulating principles for culturally grounded AI development for model makers. Themes included cultural integrity, transparency, environmental accountability, fair compensation, and community stewardship.

The project convened:

- Artists
- Cultural Practitioners
- AI Researchers
- Students
- Technologists

Through workshops and roundtables across:

- India
- Germany
- the United Kingdom
- the United States

The initiative explored how underrepresented visual cultures and local knowledge systems can be integrated into generative AI workflows through collaborative design practices.

RESEARCH QUESTIONS

RQ1: How can participatory design methodologies inform the development of inclusive generative AI systems?
RQ2: How do artists, educators, technologists, and cultural stakeholders understand and negotiate issues of bias representation, ownership, and consent in AI systems?
RQ3: Can collaborative dataset creation and participatory model training redistribute agency within AI development processes?

METHODOLOGY

The project combines qualitative, praxis-based, and design research methods:

- participatory design research
- qualitative inquiry
- practice-based research
- speculative and critical design
- collaborative prototyping

METHODS

- **Workshops & Roundtables:** Participants critically examined AI bias, cultural representation, authorship, consent, provenance, and environmental impact.
- **Co-Design Activities:** Participants collaboratively discussed dataset creation, generated image and video outputs in their unique, aesthetic styles, and reflected on cultural authenticity. Rather than treating datasets as neutral repositories, the project approached dataset construction as a curatorial and interpretive practice.
- **Prototype Development:** The project developed an AI Image Trainer and an AI Video Generator, allowing users to fine-tune models on culturally specific and underrepresented image datasets.
- **Manifesto Development:** An open collaborative manifesto was iteratively developed through participant feedback and discussion.

PARTICIPATORY DESIGN FRAMEWORK

- Community Engagement
- Collaborative Dataset Creation
- Participatory Model Training
- Critical Reflection
- Iterative Feedback
- Shared Governance

This framework positions communities not as passive subjects of AI systems, but as active co-creators of datasets, tools, and ethical frameworks.

KEY FINDINGS

Participatory AI redistributes agency.

- Dominant AI datasets marginalise local communities.
- Workshops fostered critical AI literacy.
- Prototype tools enabled inclusive outputs in the form of unique images/videos.
- Inclusive AI needs collaborative governance.

Outputs from the project included:

1. A collaboratively authored, open manifesto outlining ethical frameworks around representation, consent, provenance, and ecological impact; and
2. Prototype AI Image Trainer and Video Generator tools that enable users to fine-tune models on underrepresented image datasets. it is open source and reusable.
3. Diverse datasets grounded in cultural and contextual understanding.

A total of 1640 runs over 9 workshops created image and video outputs that better reflected specific cultural aesthetics, visual traditions, and contextual references.

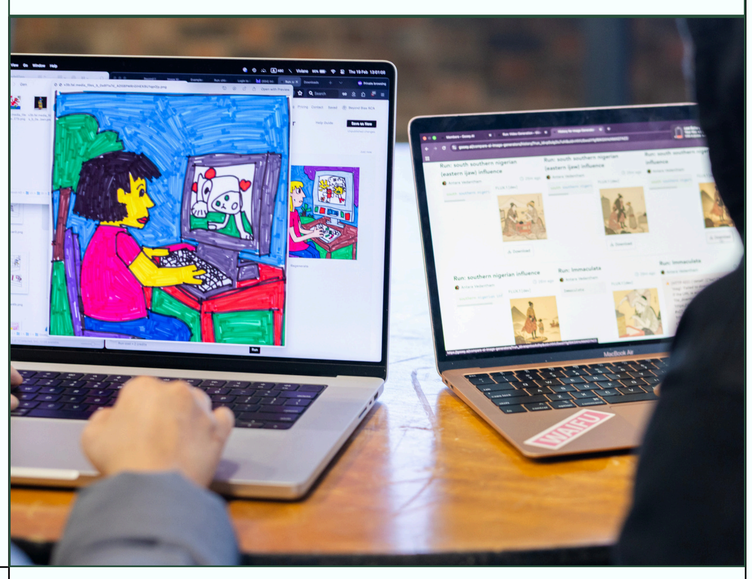
COMMUNITY ENGAGEMENT

200+
Workshop Participants

24
Member Organisations in Stakeholders Consortium

9
Workshops

2
Roundtable sessions



CONCLUSION

Findings from the workshops suggest that participatory and practice-based approaches can redistribute ownership within AI development, enabling communities to actively shape their representation in generative systems. Involving diverse stakeholders in the design process also fostered critical reflection on issues of authorship, ownership, sustainability, and the broader socio-cultural implications of AI.
Rather than framing bias solely as a technical problem, Beyond Bias positions AI bias as cultural, political, ecological, and infrastructural. The project demonstrates that inclusive AI requires not only diverse datasets, but also participatory governance structures, collaborative design processes, and the integration of community knowledge directly into AI development workflows.

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